

YEAR 9 (AFTER PREP) · THEME 3 · PERSONAL LIFE & WELL-BEING

Reading

B2.1

Finding Balance: A Student's Story · The Hidden Link Between Sleep, Stress and Social Life

Hazırlık Sonrası 9. Sınıf

Name – Surname

Class

No

Date

Aim Understand the main idea and details, make inferences and connect the text to your own life.

1 Before you read

Make predictions before you read.

1. Look at the title. What do you think "finding balance" means for a student?
2. Have you ever felt exhausted from doing too many things at once? What happened?

Finding Balance: A Student's Story

- 1 Last year, seventeen-year-old Deniz used to think that being busy meant being successful. Between classes, football practice, and a part-time weekend job, he barely had time to sleep, let alone see his friends. He used to skip breakfast most mornings and would often stay up past midnight finishing homework, telling himself that he could rest "later."
- 2 Then, one Tuesday in November, everything caught up with him. While he was sitting in a maths lesson, Deniz suddenly felt dizzy and exhausted, and he couldn't concentrate on anything the teacher was saying. He went to see the school counsellor, who explained that his body and mind were showing clear signs of burnout — a state that happens when stress builds up for too long without enough rest, food, or social contact.
- 3 With the counsellor's help, Deniz slowly started to rebuild a more balanced routine. He began going to bed thirty minutes earlier, ate a proper breakfast, and — most importantly — made time each week to see his friends without talking about school at all. He also learned a short mindfulness exercise to do whenever he felt anxious before a test.
- 4 Six months later, Deniz still works hard, but he no longer believes that exhaustion is a sign of success. "I used to think rest was a waste of time," he says, "but now I know that looking after my physical, mental and social health is what actually helps me perform better — in football, in exams, and just in everyday life."

250 words

2 While you read

5 × 2 pts

Circle the correct option.

1. What is the main idea of the text?
 - a Deniz stopped playing football because of stress.
 - b Deniz learned that balancing physical, mental and social health matters more than staying constantly busy.
 - c The school counsellor told Deniz to stop studying completely.
2. Deniz's counsellor explained that his symptoms were signs of _____.
3. Which of these was NOT part of Deniz's new routine?
 - a Going to bed earlier b Eating a proper breakfast c Quitting football completely
4. Deniz felt dizzy while he was doing his weekend job. ☐ Correct ☐ Incorrect
5. Deniz learned a short _____ exercise to use whenever he felt anxious before a test.

3 After you read*Write short answers. Then compare with a partner.*

1. Do you agree with Deniz that being busy doesn't always mean being successful? Why or why not?

2. Write one sentence describing a habit you used to have that you have now changed.

1 Before you read*Make predictions before you read.*

1. What do you think the connection is between sleep and getting ill?

2. Do you think talking to friends can actually reduce stress? Why or why not?

The Hidden Link Between Sleep, Stress and Social Life

- 1 Most teenagers know that sleep matters, but few realise how closely it is connected to both mental health and the immune system. When you don't get enough sleep, your body produces more of the stress hormone cortisol, which can make you feel more anxious and less able to concentrate. At the same time, a tired immune system finds it harder to fight off common illnesses, so poor sleepers often catch more colds during exam periods.

- 2 Chronic stress — stress that continues for weeks or months rather than a single stressful day — has a similar double effect. It doesn't just affect how we feel emotionally; research shows it can also weaken the immune system and even affect digestion and heart rate over time. This is why doctors increasingly describe physical and mental health as two sides of the same coin rather than separate issues.
- 3 Social health plays a surprisingly powerful role here too. Studies of students have found that those with strong social support — close friends, family, or a supportive club or team — tend to cope with stress far more effectively than those who feel isolated. Simply talking to someone about a problem, rather than facing it alone, appears to lower stress levels almost immediately.
- 4 The good news is that small changes can make a real difference. Experts recommend a consistent sleep schedule, at least one proper conversation a day with someone you trust, and short breaks for physical movement between long study sessions. None of these require expensive equipment or hours of free time — just a little planning and, perhaps, a change of mindset about what "looking after yourself" really means.

275 words

2 While you read

5 × 2 pts

Circle the correct option.

1. According to the text, what happens when teenagers don't get enough sleep?
 - a Their immune system gets stronger.
 - b Their stress hormone levels rise and their immune system weakens.
 - c They automatically become more social.
 2. Stress that continues for weeks or months, rather than a single day, is called _____ stress.
 3. What does the text say about students with strong social support?
 - a They cope with stress more effectively.
 - b They sleep less than other students.
 - c They are less likely to get colds.
 4. The text says that looking after yourself always requires expensive equipment. ☐ Correct ☐ Incorrect
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5. What is the writer's main purpose in this text?
 - a To warn readers to stop studying
 - b To explain how physical, mental and social health are connected and suggest simple changes
 - c To advertise a new sleep product

3 After you read

Write short answers. Then compare with a partner.

1. Which of the experts' suggestions (sleep schedule, daily conversation, movement breaks) would be easiest for you to try this week?

2. Write two sentences summarising the link between sleep, stress and social health, in your own words.
